

Leonard Yang Liu

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Education

- 2022–2027 **Ph.D. in Management**, University of Maryland, Robert H. Smith School of Business
(Major: Accounting; Minor: Economics)
- 2017–2020 **M.S. in Management**, Peking University, HSBC Business School
- 2012–2016 **B.S. in Accounting**, Huazhong University of Science and Technology

Research Interests

New Technology in Accounting; Financial Intermediaries; Capital Markets; Financial Information Processing; Behavioral Finance

Job Market Paper

“Synthesizing the Consensus: Generative AI, LLM Visibility, and the Integration of Multi-Provider Consensus Forecasts” (solo-authored)

- *Dissertation committee*: Musa Subasi (chair), Michael Kimbrough (co-chair), Rebecca Hann, Nick Seybert, Jingyi Qian, Erkut Ozbay (Dean’s representative)
- *Presented at*: University of Maryland

Abstract: This paper studies how generative AI (GenAI) tools facilitate financial information processing in the setting of the market’s integration and use of multi-provider analyst consensus forecasts. Using S&P 1500 firm-quarters over 2021–2025 covering all five major forecast data providers (FDPs), I first document a wider, more selective use of consensus after ChatGPT: prices respond more to more-accurate providers and reweight from I/B/E/S where it loses relative accuracy. I then construct an accuracy-weighted consensus, and announcement returns load on it increasingly over two heuristics: I/B/E/S and the equal-weighted average across the five FDPs. This shift strengthens with GenAI’s retrieval capability and concentrates where providers disagree most, especially where that disagreement most likely reflects methodological differences across FDPs. Measuring the visibility of each firm’s consensus forecasts to GenAI tools using the GPT-4o model, I find the synthesis benefit concentrates in high-visibility firms. The results show how GenAI powers investors’ processing of multi-provider consensus.

Working Papers

- [1] **“AI-Powered Analysts”** with Michael Kimbrough and Musa Subasi
- *Status*: R&R at *The Accounting Review*
 - *Honors*: Best Paper Award in Fintech, SFA 2024
 - *Presented at*: University of Maryland; SFA Annual Conference
- [2] **“The Role of Generative AI in Democratizing Investment Research: Evidence from Crowd-sourced Forecasts”** with Musa Subasi
- *Status*: Ready to submit
 - *Presented at*: University of Maryland; University of Missouri[‡]
- [3] **“Stepping Into the Spotlight: CFO Debuts in Conference Calls”** with Nick Seybert

- *Status:* In final preparation for submission
- *Presented at:* University of Maryland

([‡]Presented by coauthor; full abstracts on page 4)

Honors, Awards & Fellowships

2026	Frank T. Paine Award for Academic Achievement
2025	Deloitte Foundation Scholarship Nomination
2025	Long Jiang Graduate Student Fellowship
2024	Best Paper Award in Fintech, SFA Annual Meeting
2022–2027	Robert H. Smith School of Business Doctoral Fellowship
2017–2020	Peking University First-Class Scholarship

Conference Participation & Presentation

2026	AAA Annual Meeting (Aug); University of Maryland* (Apr, May); FARS Midyear Meeting (Jan)
2025	Washington Accounting Research Symposium (May); FARS Midyear Meeting (Jan); FARS Doctoral Symposium (Jan)
2024	SFA Annual Meeting* [†] (Nov); University of Maryland* (Jan, Oct); AAA Annual Meeting (Jul); Washington Accounting Research Symposium (Jun)
2023	Washington Accounting Research Symposium (Jun); Financial Information Systems and Cybersecurity Meeting (Jan)
2022	Washington Accounting Research Symposium (Jul)

(*Presenter; [†]Discussant)

Teaching

Instructor

Jun–Jul 2025	Principles of Accounting I: Financial Accounting (BMGT 220) University of Maryland, Robert H. Smith School of Business Course evaluation 3.82/4.0; Instructor evaluation 3.89/4.0
Jan 2025	Principles of Accounting I: Financial Accounting (BMGT 220) University of Maryland, Robert H. Smith School of Business Course evaluation 3.77/4.0; Instructor evaluation 3.85/4.0

Other Teaching Experience

Sep 2026	GenAI and Business Research , <i>Representative PhD Student Speaker</i> (scheduled) University of Maryland, Robert H. Smith School of Business
Sep 2025	Fundamentals of Business Research , <i>Guest Speaker</i> University of Maryland, Robert H. Smith School of Business
2018–2020	Teaching Assistant Peking University, HSBC Business School

Professional Experience

2022–2027	Graduate Assistant, University of Maryland, College Park, MD
2020–2022	Investment Manager, CSCEC, Beijing, China
2018	Security Research Intern, Haitong Securities, Shanghai, China
2016–2017	Audit Associate, Ernst & Young, Wuhan, China

Academic Review, Service & Membership

2024–	Ad hoc reviewer, Behavioral Research in Accounting
2022–	Academic conference reviewer: AAA Annual Meeting (2025), China Accounting and Finance Review Conference (2025), SFA Annual Meeting (2024), Accounting, Behavior & Organizations Research Conference (2022)
2023–	Treasurer, Association of Doctoral Students, UMD Smith
2022–	Member, American Accounting Association

Skills

Statistics	SAS, Stata, R
Programming	Python (NLP & ML), oTree, LaTeX, HTML
Languages	Mandarin Chinese (native), English (proficient)

References

Musa Subasi (chair)

Associate Professor of Accounting
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Nick Seybert

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Michael Kimbrough (co-chair)

Area Chair & Professor of Accounting;
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Rebecca Hann

Associate Dean of Research & Doctoral Programs;
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[1] **“AI-Powered Analysts”** with Michael Kimbrough and Musa Subasi

Abstract: We examine how brokerages’ institutional adoption of artificial intelligence (AI), measured from AI skill requirements in research-related job postings, shapes sell-side analyst work. AI adoption varies across brokerages and is predicted by peer adoption, organizational capacity, analyst human capital, and institutional demand. Comparing the same analyst-firm pair over time, analysts at higher-adoption brokerages issue more accurate earnings forecasts. The gains are larger when forecasts rely more on public, machine-readable information: early in the cycle, for firms with lower information asymmetry and more readable disclosures, and among technically trained and less-experienced analysts. Using intraday decision fatigue, we show that AI substitutes for analysts’ cognitive effort within the forecasting task: it attenuates fatigue-related accuracy losses and herding. Freed capacity is redeployed toward management access. Forecasts by analysts at higher-adoption brokerages elicit stronger price reactions, and adopters shift hiring toward senior analysts. Overall institutional AI reallocates analyst work between machine-processing and human-access margins.

[2] **“The Role of Generative AI in Democratizing Investment Research: Evidence from Crowdsourced Forecasts”** with Musa Subasi

Abstract: We examine whether generative AI (GenAI) helps level the playing field between professional and non-professional forecasters. Using crowdsourced forecasts from Estimote, we find that the accuracy gap between these groups narrows significantly following the release of ChatGPT, driven primarily by improvements among non-professional contributors. Exploiting ChatGPT service outages as a quasi-natural experiment, we find that forecast accuracy declines during outages, particularly for non-professional contributors, consistent with these contributors relying on GenAI for earnings-related information processing. GenAI adoption is associated with more accurate and more independent forecasts, with the largest gains concentrated among non-professionals. Cross-sectional tests indicate that GenAI’s benefits are more pronounced when disclosures are less readable but are attenuated when analyst forecast dispersion is high, suggesting that GenAI is less effective in settings with greater information asymmetry. Finally, earnings announcement returns are more strongly associated with earnings surprises derived from non-professional forecasts in the post-ChatGPT period. Overall, our evidence suggests that GenAI democratizes investment research by enhancing the financial information-processing capacity of non-professionals.

[3] **“Stepping Into the Spotlight: CFO Debuts in Conference Calls”** with Nick Seybert

Abstract: This paper investigates whether CFOs who debut on their first earnings conference call exhibit a tendency to stay in their “comfort zone” by emphasizing numbers and accounting jargon rather than qualitative strategic information as a means of maintaining credibility in the face of potential public scrutiny, both because CFOs have more prior experience with accounting and quantitative information than with soft information, and because such information is verifiable and objective. Analyzing a large sample of earnings call transcripts, we find that debuting CFOs exhibit a significantly greater reliance on quantitative language and accounting jargon at the expense of softer strategic disclosures. These trends decline nearly monotonically over subsequent calls. The debut effect is particularly pronounced in settings where a new CFO is expected to experience greater pressure and uncertainty: when it is the CFO’s first time in the C-Suite, for higher-growth firms, and when the firm reports a loss during the first conference call. We also find that CFOs engaging in greater comfort-zone behavior are less likely to be promoted to CEO at their current firm or to be hired into a C-Suite position at another firm. Finally, comfort-zone behavior does not measurably impact market or analyst reaction to conference calls. Taken together, our results suggest that debut pressure encourages CFOs to focus on accounting and quantitative information over softer strategic information during early conference calls, and that this behavior worsens future career outcomes and does not benefit the firm with respect to investors or analysts.